8.3 Socialism

Socialism is an ideology that supports public ownership of property and natural resources. It is fundamentally opposed to Liberalism that believes in the private ownership of property. There are many kinds of socialism like democratic socialism, evolutionary socialism, Fabian socialism, guild socialism etc. The terms 'Socialism' and 'Communism' are at times interchangeably used. But Karl Marx introduced a distinction by describing his socialism and ideology as scientific socialism and other prevailing kinds as Utopian socialism.

A. Utopian Socialism

Many thinkers in the 19th century had questioned the negative consequences of liberalism. They strove to protect the interests of the working class. Robert Owen was an industrialist and a philanthropist. He started the cooperative movement and experimental socialist communities in England to realise betterment in the conditions of the workers. He associated the workers in the management of his industries and showed that profits can be increased by the joint endeavour between workers and employers. He appealed to the reason of the fellow capitalists to take into account the welfare of the working classes.Saint Simon, a French industrialist and thinker, argued that the welfare of the working class must also be taken into consideration for realising an efficient economy and effective society.

Charles Fourier, another French thinker, suggested the socialist reconstruction of the society by forming association of producers termed as phalanges. Both Saint Simon and Charles Fourier appealed to the conscience of the capitalists to improve the miserable state of the workers. These three notable theorists advocated ideas in favour of the workers in 19th century. Karl Marx described their thoughts as Utopian Socialism as they provided only a superficial understanding of capitalism and their alternative schemes are wishful and utopian in nature. He claimed that, in contrast his communism is based on scientific understanding of capitalism meriting the name of Scientific Socialism.

B. Democratic Socialism

Democratic Socialism as the nomenclature indicates combines the two systems of socialism and democracy to provide a unique political and economic system to promote equality and freedom. It differs from Marxism in its conception of the State. It believes that the State is not an instrument of exploitation of workers by the capitalists. Rather, the State is an instrument of social welfare. The State must be made democratic. All classes in society own the State. Socialism can be established only through the State. It will not and should not wither away as Marxism predicted.

Democratic Socialism argues that socialism can be established through evolutionary and peaceful means. It's methodology of change characterized as gradualism or ballot box socialism. It dismisses revolutionary, violent struggle as unnecessary. Democratic Socialism argues for harmonious relationship among classes and class differences must

11th Std Political Science Eng Medium Vol-2_Chapter 8.indd 148 2/5/2020 5:02:43 PM